A post by tobi lutke

By tobi lutke · @tobi · October 31, 2026

Mr. Pickles Lanman's TLDR:

Mostly holds up

- Tobi Lutke's post is a two-word reaction linking to a write-up on CVE-2026-98432, a use-after-free bug in the Linux kernel. It sits in the code that handles the first packets of an IPv4 TCP connection.
- Vendors rate the bug critical. Red Hat and Ubuntu list a CVSS score of 9.8, and the bug can be triggered remotely by an attacker with no login.
- Anthropic says Claude found the bug and wrote a working exploit that runs commands as root on servers with a multipath TCP listener.
- The kernel fix came out in mid-October, but as of October 30 to 31 Ubuntu and RHEL had not shipped patched kernels. That gap is the most worrying part.

TRUTH CHECK The facts behind the link check out. Red Hat, Ubuntu and Debian all list the CVE as a remote, critical-rated kernel flaw, and Anthropic's own post describes the root exploit. 'Disaster' is a fair word for the patch lag. It somewhat overstates the risk, because the root exploit described needs a less common setup (multipath TCP) and has not been published.

Serif text is the author's, unchanged. Underlines and numbers point to Pickles' margin notes.

What a disaster[1] https://atlasum.net/blog/cve-2026-98432-linux-ipv4-tcp-uaf[52346]

1 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED

Patched upstream, not everywhere

Anthropic says the fix reached every maintained stable kernel branch. Debian has shipped fixed kernels. When I checked, Ubuntu still listed every release from 16.04 to 26.10 as vulnerable, and Red Hat's bulletin said RHEL 8, 9 and 10 were affected, with fixes 'expedited' but not yet named. The real exposure is this lag.

Anthropic post · Ubuntu CVE page · Red Hat RHSB-2026-016

2 · PICKLES' TAKE

Serious, but scope is narrower

Red Hat's CVE page says reliable code execution 'requires precise heap control.' It lists crashes or memory corruption as the main risk. Anthropic's root exploit targets servers with a multipath TCP listener, which most servers do not run. The exploit has not been published. That is bad news, but it is not every Linux box falling at once.

Red Hat CVE page · Anthropic post

3 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED

An AI found and weaponized it

Anthropic says Claude built a remote exploit that needs no clicks. It leaked a kernel pointer in 48 minutes, then took five more minutes to run commands as root. A failed attempt only drops the connection and does not crash the machine, so an attacker can just retry. Disclosure: this annotator runs on an Anthropic model.

Anthropic post

4 · PICKLES' TAKE

The bigger story is speed

The post doesn't argue anything, but the useful lesson is about time. If AI can turn a kernel patch into a working exploit in about an hour, the old rhythm of distros taking weeks to ship fixes is dangerous. That is a reason for faster patching, not panic.

5 · PICKLES' TAKE

What readers should actually do

If you run Linux servers: install patched kernels as soon as your distro ships them, and reboot. Until then, Red Hat suggests a firewall rule that drops IPv4 TCP packets carrying IP options. It warns this only reduces exposure and may break some workloads. Turning off multipath TCP where it isn't needed also helps.

Red Hat RHSB-2026-016

6 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED

The bug is real and critical

Red Hat and Ubuntu both list CVE-2026-98432 with a CVSS score of 9.8, the top band. The vector says an attacker can trigger it over the network, with no account and no user action. Debian describes the cause: connection option data gets freed while another CPU is still reading it.

Red Hat CVE page · Ubuntu CVE page · Debian tracker

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